shape, the eternal competition between Tokyo and Beijing is poised to enter an even more intense period. This dynamic is as likely in its own way to shape Asia in the coming decades as that between Washington and Beijing.

III.

To make a claim that Asia's future will be decided between China and Japan may sound fanciful, especially after two decades of extraordinary economic growth has vaulted China into becoming the world's largest economy (at least according to purchasing power parity calculations)[1] and Japan has seen a concomitant quarter century of apparent economic stagnation. Yet the same claim would have sounded just as unrealistic back in 1980, except in reverse, when Japan had racked up years of double-digit and high single-digit economic returns while China had barely emerged from the generational disaster of Mao Zedong's Great Leap Forward and the Cultural Revolution. Just a few decades ago, Japan was predicted to be the global financial power par excellence, countered only by the United States.

For most of history, however, it would have seemed delusional to compare Japan with China. Island powers can rarely compete with cohesive continental states. Once China's unified empires emerged, starting with the Qin in 221 BCE, Japan was dwarfed by its continental neighbor. Even during its periods of disunity, many of China's fragmented and competing states were nearly as large as, or larger than, all of Japan. Thus, during the half century of the Three Kingdoms, when Japan's queen of Wa paid tribute to Cao Wei, each of the three domains, Wei, Shu, and Wu, controlled more territory than Japan's nascent imperial house. China's natural sense of superiority was reflected in the very word used for Japan, *Wa* (倭), which is usually accepted to mean "dwarf people" or possibly "submissive people," thus fitting Chinese ideology regarding other ethnicities in ancient times. Similarly, Japan's geographical isolation from the continent meant that the dangerous